

# Choice of Research Topic and Career Outcomes among Economists

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# The Question

Do economists who study sensitive topics face career penalties?

Sensitive topics: race, gender, discrimination, religion, immigration

- ▶ Are they **silenced** by the profession?
- ▶ Or do they **self-censor** strategically?

# Data

Two sources linked together:

- ▶ **JEL Annual Dissertations** — 33,839 US economics PhDs, 1990–2024
- ▶ **RePec** — 5.1 million publications, full author profiles

Final panel: 6,131 authors, 66,840 person-year observations

# Methods

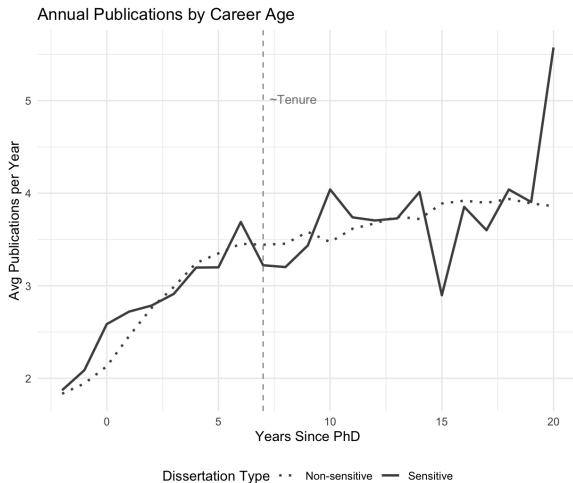
**Treatment:** dissertation on a sensitive topic (keyword match on title)

**Two specifications:**

- ▶ OLS: does treatment predict annual publication count?
- ▶  $n_{it} = \beta_1 \text{sens}_i + \beta_2 \text{yrsphd}_{it} + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{it}$
- ▶ Probit: does treatment predict publishing sensitive work, and does this change after tenure ( $\geq 7$  years post-PhD)?
- ▶  $\Pr(y_{it} = 1) = \Phi(\beta_1 \text{sens}_i \times \text{post}_{it} + \beta_2 \text{yrsphd}_{it} + \gamma_t)$

Controls: years since PhD, graduation year fixed effects

# Findings



**No publication penalty:**

OLS:  $\hat{\beta} = 0.09$ ,  $p = 0.23$

**Research shifts after tenure:**

Before tenure: +37 pp

After tenure: +26 pp

$\Delta = -11$  pp,  $p < 0.001$

# What Did We Learn?

- ▶ No raw publication penalty for sensitive-topic researchers
- ▶ But they are significantly less likely to continue sensitive research after tenure
- ▶ Consistent with **strategic self-censorship** before tenure

The profession may be systematically underproducing research on inequality and discrimination.